

POWER OF FAMINE

left of carefully tilled, sown and irrigated land are yellow and brown beds of devastated paddy fields.

The 300-odd families in Khanpui brave hunger and starvation together. They share whatever food they have and brave the cold to set mouse traps and kill the moving army of rats that have been eating away all their crops. "They've been coming since last year," says D. Chawngthang. He is 62 and about to begin his night-long vigil killing as many rats as he can, collecting Rs 2 for every dead rat.

The last time the bamboo flowered, in 1959, the famine it caused gave birth to an underground movement that lasted 26 years and led to the formation of the state of Mizoram itself. This time, the picturesque capital of Aizawl, which houses a third of the state's 10 lakh people, is quietly going about its business as there are no outward signs of a raging famine in the villages.

But in people's minds it is as if the struggles of the 1960s have recommenced. The local daily newspaper *Aizawl Post* reports crop destruction and starvation, and most locals believe it is the beginning of another long fight for them against deprivation. So what if it is still to touch the city, the unpleasant memories of the last *mautam* (bamboo famine) have not gone away.

The phenomenon of the flowering of the bamboo is an ecological freak.

About 31 per cent of the total area of Mizoram is covered with thick bamboo forests, housing 26 species of bamboo. One particular species, the *Melocanna baccifera* accounts for 90 per cent of the bamboo forests found in the north-eastern state.

Once every 48 years, the bamboo flowers, bears fruit and dries completely to give rise to new plants. The fruit from this plant has a 50 per cent starch content which serves to increase the reproductive capabilities of rats that feed on it. In the year the bamboo flowers, rats give birth to over a dozen offspring in a month, and within a year the entire rodent population multiplies over a dozen times and begins to eat anything it can find. Usually the rats begin with the rice fields.

Farmers have tried every other kind of crop, from brinjal to soya and even bitter gourd but with little luck against the rats. During the 1959 famine, they had not attacked underground crops such as ginger, turmeric and yam. But this year, they have not only attacked these, but have been found nibbling on bamboo-matted floors inside houses. Experts reckon the rodent population in the state could well be 10 times the human one.

The first signs of the *mautam* are visible around Khanpui's destroyed fields. In the last one year, no household has been able to harvest even two tins

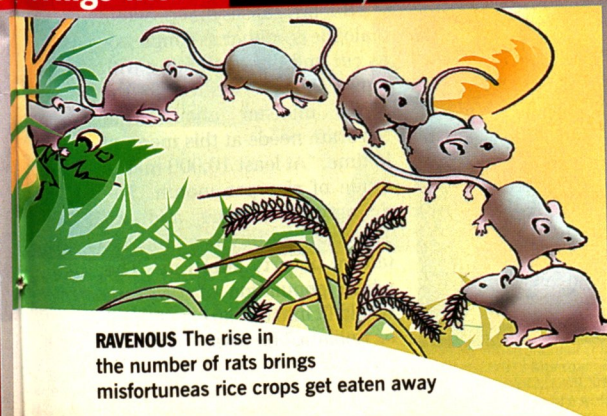
of rice (one tin holds about 70 kg of paddy and a tin of seed is expected to yield at least 70-100 tins of harvest). "We do not have money even for our daily needs," says Lalrochunga, a Khanpui local. The state government ran a food-for-work programme only for 10 days in the entire year here, effectively raising the household income up to a mere Rs 1,000.

As early as in 1998, Padmashree C. Rokhuma, also called the "Pied Piper of Aizawl", had warned the government to institute a scheme to collect rat tails and burn them, hoping that it would act as an incentive for villagers to capture rats. The scheme was discontinued after a few months because the government was not convinced that the *mautam* was such a serious threat.

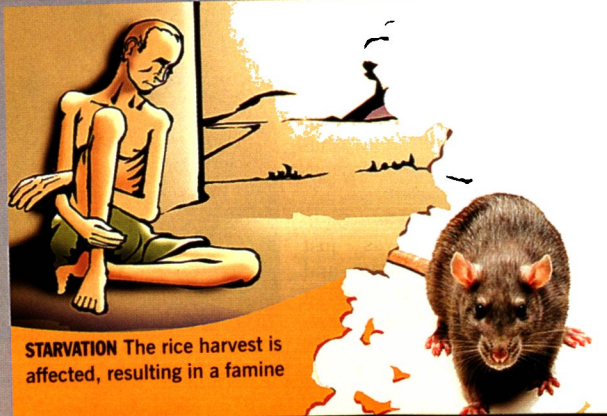
Now, almost all of Mizoram, and parts of Manipur and Tripura, are reeling under acute food shortages due to crop devastation. Rokhuma's scheme was renewed only last month, and while he presided over the burning of 20,000 rat-tails in a week—in a month, over four lakh rat-tails have been burnt—he believes it is not enough.

The 90-year-old naturalist and social worker fears the writing is on the wall. The flowering, which started last year, has already dried up in most areas, but its worst effects are now being felt. Rokhuma explains that the rats attack the crops because they don't

brings with it **DEATH, DESTRUCTION AND SUFFERING** for the state



RAVENOUS The rise in the number of rats brings misfortune as rice crops get eaten away



STARVATION The rice harvest is affected, resulting in a famine